when he was using marital connections to stabilize his empire and now sought to remedy the situation. After much discussion, it was agreed that, according to the Shia custom of mut'ah* marriage, a man may marry any number of wives. Shaikh Abd un-Nabi, who seemed to prevaricate upon this matter, earned Akbar's sharp displeasure and finally the Padshah appointed a new qazi, the Shia Qazi Maliki, more amenable to his particular matrimonial problems, who decreed that Akbar's mut'ah marriages were legal.

From these discussions at the ibadat khana it was clear that Akbar was concerned with the legality of the status of his wives and his own standing in the eyes of God and in society. There is a sense of Akbar struggling to right the wrongs committed during the vagaries of his youth and of accepting his own fallibility. This was quite in contrast to the views of an orthodox man like Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi,* for example, who believed that Islamic laws regarding marriage and concubinage were there expressly to protect men's enjoyment of women. The four wives, the instrument of divorce, the provision for nikah marriage, were primarily to allow men as many sexual liberties as possible. For Shaikh Sirhindi, women's views were quite inconsequential for they were naqis ul-aql, without intellect.

Another theologian whose fall was imminent was Abdullah Sultanpuri, the makhdum ul-Mulk. When the discussions had started at the ibadat khana, Akbar had summoned him 'in order to annoy him' and pitted him against the precocious Abu'l Fazl. Sensing the winds of change, and following the lead of Akbar, who would keep interrupting Abdullah Sultanpuri, the other courtiers also interjected to ridicule the theologian so that he soon became, according to Badauni, a living example of the Koranic warning—'and some of you shall have life prolonged to a miserable age'. Badauni also believed that 'from this day forward the road to opposition and differences in opinion lay open, and remained so, till Akbar was appointed Mujtahid of the Empire'. This mood of sharp-edged bonhomie seems to have extended to the court, too, for Badauni narrates an incident in which Deb Chand Rajah Manjholah caused great amusement among the courtiers by jokingly suggesting that Allah had a great respect for cows since that animal is mentioned in the first chapter of the Koran.†

There were other signs of a change in the texture of the court at Fatehpur Sikri. Attracted by Akbar's new capital, its dazzling wealth, and the climate of religious and cultural experimentation, learned and talented